

4. The students' application period begins by end of March. This is perhaps the most crucial time. After an initial round of discussion with mentors, students start working on a proposal and submit it online at Melange. The application should incorporate feedback, and depending on the organisation, mentors might ask you to work on your proposal on a public wiki or submit it privately. We'll talk about writing a good proposal and other important things to keep in mind while applying.
5. The submission of application deadline is the first week of April. This is usually ten days after the application period has begun.
6. The interim period is a two-week period after the deadline for accepting applications. The organisations rank the proposals and might ask students further questions to clarify their doubts about the proposal. Before the results are announced, students who successfully qualify for multiple projects are allotted a single project by an official committee of administrators from different organisations and Google staff members.
7. The results are declared on the programme's website (around April 25).

Read the entire FAQ at http://www.google-melange.com/gsoc/document/show/gsoc_program/google/gsoc2012/faqs.

Things to keep in mind while applying

1. *Start early and communicate effectively.* It is very important to get in touch with mentors early and grab their attention. Communication is the key. Let the community know that you are interested in a particular idea. Hang out on the IRC and talk to fellow students. A decent proposal submitted on the final day, without any prior conversation, will most likely be rejected.
2. *Show plenty of enthusiasm!* Mentors are looking for enthusiastic and committed people who they are sure will dedicate their entire summer faithfully to the project. There is no substitute for enthusiasm.
3. *Choose a project you're passionate about.* Students usually apply for projects they use in day-to-day life and are passionate about. If not, they select something that intrigues them and falls within their level of expertise.
4. *Do a small task for the community.* A great way to prove your competency during the proposal period is to submit trivial bug fixes or minor feature enhancements.
5. *Have a nice github/your choice of code hosting> profile.* Many organisations want to look at the past open source code you have written. In the popular hacker culture, everyone firmly believes '*GitHub is your resume*'!

There are some must-read official student guidelines from Google at <http://code.google.com/p/google-summer-of-code/wiki/AdviceforStudents>.

Writing a great proposal

Most students find writing a proposal a daunting task. Quite a lot of applications submitted by students are bad and regarded as spam. Here are some basic guidelines for writing a great proposal:

1. *Focus on quality, not quantity.* Submitting a large number

of copy-pasted proposals to a number of organisations will hardly be helpful. Focus on two proposals at the most.

2. *Follow the format.* Most organisations provide an 'ideal proposal' format. Try to strictly adhere to it and fill in all the required details. It makes work easy for the organisation and mentors.
3. *Get an unofficial review of your proposal.* A very good idea is to make your mentor go through the proposal once before submission. The changes incorporated from feedback can drastically improve the quality of your proposal.
4. *Chalk out a rough timeline.* It is recommended that you include a rough timeline as to how you plan to complete the project. You could break it up module by module, or in any other fashion that seems appropriate. A lot of organisations have a 'Timeline' sub-heading as a part of the proposal format.
5. *Compose a detailed proposal and advertise yourself.* Describe in depth the challenges involved in the project, previous work done (if any), and how you will work on solving the problem and implementing the project. Write briefly about yourself, answering the question 'Why are you the most suitable candidate for the project?' To persuade the community, refer to your past experience in similar projects, and prior experience with the platform and technology.

The post-selection timetable

There are four major milestones in the programme, once the students have been selected:

1. The community bonding period (the month of May). Students interact with the community, and get to know the projects and people. This is to facilitate interactions and hopefully make GSoC students long-term contributors to the project.
2. Beginning of coding (end of May). Students receive their initial payment (US\$ 500) and start coding!
3. Mid-term evaluation (mid-July). Each mentor evaluates the student's work and sends an official progress report to Google. If the students' work is satisfactory up to that point, they receive another part-payment (US\$ 2250).
4. Final pencil-down deadline (end August). Mentors finally evaluate the entire work and submit a report. Students are issued the final payment (US\$ 2250) upon positive feedback and the results of GSoC are announced. The students submit their code to Google.

Winding up!

GSoC is a truly amazing platform to learn, code and contribute to open source. Hope to see more students and LFY readers participating from Asia next year! Happy hacking! 

By: Nitish Upreti

The author is a 2012 GSoC'er working with the 'Berkman Center for Internet and Society, Harvard' as his mentor organisation. A Rubyist by heart, a technology start-up enthusiast and a classic rock fan, he tweets as @nitish.